Calvary Women's Services
A safe, caring place for tonight; support, hope and change for tomorrow.

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2016 – 2019 Strategic Plan

Introduction

The time is now. Calvary Women's Services and the community we serve are both at a critical juncture. The Washington DC region is facing a crisis. Our community lacks affordable housing and homelessness continues to increase. Our governments – local and Federal – are increasingly focused on tackling the issue and implementing solutions. At the same time, women struggling with homelessness face unique hurdles in securing and sustaining affordable, safe housing. The situation is both complex and urgent.

Calvary Women's Services is financially strong, clear on our priorities and mission and built on a successful, proven model. We have established ourselves in the Anacostia neighborhood, a community fostering equity in the midst of economic development. As one of the only providers of services exclusively for women in our region, Calvary has a unique understanding of the needs of women. Affordable housing and quality, comprehensive services can have a profound impact not only on individual women, but also on their families, neighborhoods and broader community. Calvary is also uniquely positioned to lift women's voices and promote women's issues across our community.

Calvary must take action. The confluences of challenges and opportunity call for Calvary to grow our capabilities and housing options, and become a more vocal advocate for the women we serve. We are the right organization at the right time to lead the charge in ending homelessness for women in our community.

Strategic Directions

The following strategic directions will guide our work and actively engage all levels of the organization over the next three years.

- **Housing.** Increasing the affordable housing available to women and continuing to pair housing with comprehensive, trauma-informed and personalized support services.
- **Livelihood.** Expanding opportunities for women to secure sustainable income through employment and/or government benefits that will result in long-term stability.
- **Leadership.** Raising our voice as a leader advocating with and for women in our community, leading to improved housing and services for women, greater visibility for the organization and its replicable model and expanded opportunities for collaboration.

Actions

To realize our strategic directions, Calvary will take the following actions:

- Increase our permanent supportive housing
    - We will add at least 20 new permanent supportive housing units for women through either a new Calvary-owned site and/or apartment-based placements. Calvary has developed best practices in the permanent supportive housing model through its Sister Circle program. Having purchased and renovated its Good Hope Road building in 2010, Calvary has the experience to purchase a single site that could co-locate additional permanent supportive housing units and other programs. We maintain our commitment to the wards 7 & 8 communities and strive to develop housing in one of these wards, ideally in close proximity to our existing housing locations.
- Expand Step Up DC, our employment search and placement program
    - We will expand the size and scope of the employment search and placement program to serve more women, possibly through a collaborative partnership. While the priority is maintaining a link between housing and employment, we are open to providing employment services for low-income and homeless women independent of a housing program.
- Lift up women's voices and advocate for housing, services and opportunities
    - We will engage in focused networking and advocacy to lift up women's voices, highlight the need for housing and services for women and actively promote Calvary's successful model. Calvary will also increase our visibility within the community. This effort will require a strategic communications expertise beyond Calvary's current capacity, so we will determine an appropriate plan for securing this important resource.

As Calvary moves forward in these important strategic directions, we will stay focused and strategic in funding our work through a diversity of sources. We also remain committed to providing the highest quality of services and strengthening our existing services to best meet the needs of the woman we serve. To this end, Calvary will take the following action:

- Strengthen our comprehensive support services model
    - We will provide comprehensive, on-site support services that address women's histories of mental illness, substance addiction and domestic violence, empowering women to end their homelessness. We will expand women's opportunities for education and skills building; offer faster links to government benefits for income; continue to strengthen our intensive and personalized case

management; and create an environment of peer support that is critical to women's success.

Guideposts

Calvary must be flexible and poised to leverage opportunities, especially in light of the current real estate market. We will use the following guideposts in our deliberations and decision-making processes. We will:

- **Stay true to who we are,** an organization serving women; providing high-quality services on a low staff to client ratio; creating and sustaining an environment of respect and compassion for clients, staff, volunteers and board; and supporting women's efforts to change their lives.
- **Act boldly** but carefully, always prioritizing impact, effectiveness and efficiency.
- Focus on **program growth that is incremental, sustainable and based on best practices.**
- Concentrate on the development of affordable housing, likely a **permanent supportive housing model.**
- **Expand our services,** including our employment program, being open to serving women not housed by Calvary.
- Actively pursue opportunities for **collaboration** with organizations (non-profit, for-profit, government) that share our mission or can help us further our mission.
- Seek **new sources of funding,** including the possibility of additional government funding that won't impose onerous limitations on our program model.

Sharing our Accomplishments

We are confident in the continued success of our program model in empowering women to achieve the goals they set for themselves. Calvary will gauge the success of this model with two primary measures - the number of women who secure and maintain permanent housing and the number of women who achieve and maintain financial security. Setting specific targets for each year, we will strive to continually increase the number of women who experience positive change in these two areas.

To monitor and improve our health and educational programming, we will also measure women's mental health stability, substance addiction recovery stability and educational accomplishments.

Once our strategic communications function is implemented, Calvary will develop specific voice and advocacy metrics to measure our efforts to raise our profile, give voice to the women we serve and shape the community-wide conversation about the roots of and solutions to homelessness.

Calvary remains committed to using annual goals and metrics to track and monitor progress. With the improvements to our data collection and reporting capabilities made during the last strategic plan, we will now focus on improving the ways that we share our accomplishments. We will also compare our outcomes by benchmarking to similar programs in our community. We will continue to listen and act upon the recommendations of the women we serve gathered through regular surveys and community meetings.

Guided by Our Values

The manner in which we work is as important as the work that we do. Calvary holds the following values as central to our organizational culture:

- **Respect -** We treat all people with respect by honoring their skills, knowledge, talents and inherent dignity.
- **Compassion -** We believe each person is valuable and should be treated with compassion and kindness.
- **Safety** - We create a safe environment in which to live and work, and where each person feels safe and free to be himself/herself.
- **Empowerment** - We offer everyone support to reach their own highest potential. We value self-sufficiency, independence and the accomplishment of personal goals.
- **Trustworthiness** - We live and work with integrity and openness. Each person is responsible for communicating with clarity and transparency and honoring commitments.
- **Collaboration** - We are a community of people who support one another, willing to both offer and ask for help.
- **Diversity & Inclusivity** - We are an inclusive community that welcomes all people. We value every opinion and each unique background, history and perspective.
- **Gratitude -** We live and work with humility and an awareness of the good things we have and the good people around us.
- **Grit –** We act with courage, confidence and competence. We acknowledge the critical needs of our community, and we believe that our work is powerful, effective and valuable.

Conclusion

This plan charts the way forward. It builds on Calvary's achievements and sets a bold direction for Calvary's future. This plan aligns directly to our community's strategic plan, *Homeward DC*, and articulates the critical role that Calvary will play in achieving the city-wide goal of ending homelessness.

Calvary's success depends on our ability to engage our partners – volunteers, donors, local business, government, service providers – in this important and challenging work. We are confident that together we can have a lasting impact on the lives of women, their families and our whole community. We are confident that women are ready to transform their lives and await the opportunities we will offer.